

L SHOOT

declined from 21.3 per cent in 2004 to 20.2 per cent in 2007 of the total share. In contrast, Hindi news is up from 2.7 to 4.2 per cent. Ratings are down across the board, shared between *saas-bahu* and *beti-behen* dramas—even *Ramayan*, which has been a so-called dramatic success, has actually notched an anaemic 3.19, less than half the highest-rated show, and number 18 in the list of top 20 shows. And the channel itself with an audience share of eight per cent is just a notch above Sony Entertainment TV and Doordarshan. It's reflected in the advertising rates. While about two years ago, a 10 second ad spot on a top-rated show like *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* used to cost approximately Rs 1.3 lakh, today a top-rated show like *Dulhann* only commands a lakh.

The situation is such that two years ago, both Zee TV and Star One publicised the same show, *Betigaan*, till the former went to court and yelled copycat. Easier than all this is, of course, to take a flight out to the closest television software fair and pick up an international reality show format for about Rs 1.5

crore, plus a share of the advertising and sms-phone call earnings. "It's a lot like fashion. When bell-bottoms are in, everyone wears them. When a format becomes successful, there's no harm in doing the same. It's about what the audience likes and giving it to them," says Indrani Mukherjea, CEO of INX Media, the parent company of 9X, co-founded by her husband Peter, who formerly was chairman of Star Television India.

There is a creative crisis in the industry that is causing its stars to flee, with actors refusing to participate in stories that require them to age 30 years in one flash—by Ekta Kapoor's own admission, Baa, a character on *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* is anywhere between 200 and 250 years. There is talent shortage as well, as witnessed by Balaji Telefilms's arm-twisting of late, whether it is sending Barkha Bisht a legal notice after she chose to give more time to Rajashree's *Pyaar Ke Do Naam*, *Ek Raadha Ek Shyaam*, or trying to bind Pulkit Samrat to a contract he says is unfair. From as early as the very first television hero, Amarr 'Mihir' Upadhyay, actors like Sweta Keswani, Hussain Kuwajerwala, Shweta Kawatra, Cezanne Khan

REALITY REIGNS



● **Li'l Champs started on Zee TV, and Chhote Ustad on Star TV. Now there's Chak De Bachche on 9X.**

● **After Star Plus's Nach Baliye, Sony had Jhalak Dikhla Jaa and Sahara One started Jhoom India.**

UNREAL TIMES: Participants of the musical show *Mission Ustaad* on 9X

